Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 7 4
♥ A K
♦ 10 8 6 2
♣ A K Q

♠ K 9
♥ 10 8 6
♦ K J 9
♣ 8 7 6 3 2

♠ 10 8 5 2
♥ Q J 9 4 3
♦ Q 4
♣ J 9

♠ A 6 3
♥ 7 5 2
♦ A 7 5 3
♣ 10 5 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♦	Pass	2♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥2 and West the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 7

You need two more winners and ♦s is your longest combined suit. But you can only establish one extra winner in ♦s, and before you could even do that the defenders would have taken a bunch of ♥ tricks.

So you must turn to the ♠s for the extra two winners.

You won the first ♥.

East plays low.

Which ♠ was right? If you play the ♠Q you will go down, even if East has the ♠K. He would cover and you would be held to just 2 ♠ tricks.

The only way to get 3 tricks from this holding is to play West for the ♠K. So play a ♠ to dummy's ♠A and then a small ♠ back toward your ♠ Q J.

West puts on the ♠K.

You are home-free.

You were a little lucky that West's ♠K fell on the second round.

If it had not dropped you would just have played a third round of ♠s, hoping for a 3-3 split in the suit.

You could also have gotten 3 ♠ winners with this distribution.

Board 2
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 7 5 ♥ A J 3 ♦ A 8 6 ♣ 10 9 6 3	
♠ 10 9 6 2 ♥ 8 7 6 ♦ 7 3 ♣ A K 8 2	N W E S	♠ K J 8 4 ♥ 10 9 4 2 ♦ Q J 10 5 ♣ 5
	♠ Q 3 ♥ K Q 5 ♦ K 9 4 2 ♣ Q J 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♣A

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♣A, then ♣K, ♣2. East follows once, then discards a ♠ and a ♥.

West leads the ♣A, then ♣K, ♣2. East follows once, then discards a ♠ and a ♥.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=3 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 8

There are two possibilities for getting an extra winner. If the ♦s are splitting 3-3 you could play ♦A, ♦K and another ♦ and establish the thirteenth ♦ as a winner. Or you could play East for the ♠K and lead toward your ♠Q.

The chance of East holding the ♠K is a little greater than 50%. (it is higher than the usual 50% because we know he started with only one ♣, giving him more spaces for other cards).

The chance of ♦s splitting 3-3 is about 40%.

West plays low.

You enter dummy with a ♥.

East plays low.

A small ♠ toward your ♠Q.

Did it work?

You might have thought of another possibility; duck a ♦, then play ♦A and ♦K to see if the ♦s split before you try leading toward the ♠Q.

The problem is that you might run into this very distribution. You would establish a ♦ for East and when you played a ♠ from dummy East would jump up with the ♠K and cash his winning ♦ for down 1.

Board 3
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ K J 9 ♦ A 10 4 ♣ Q J 9 2	
♠ 10 8 7 6 ♥ 10 6 4 2 ♦ 8 2 ♣ 10 7 3	N W E S	♠ K J 3 ♥ Q 7 3 ♦ K Q J 9 5 ♣ 8 4
	♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A 8 5 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A K 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♦	Pass
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♦K

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♦K, dummy plays the ♦3 and West the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If West has the ♠K or the ♥Q a simple finesse will give you the trick.

There are two problems though. The first one is that if East gets in he may take too many ♦ tricks. But the bigger problem is that West cannot possibly have either of those two high cards. You and dummy together hold 28 HCP and East must surely hold the other 12 since he opened the bidding. Neither simple finesse will work so you must try what is called a Backward Finesse.

Then play four rounds of ♣s ending in your hand.

East continues with the ♦Q; dummy plays the ♦6 and West the ♦8.

East continues with the ♦J; dummy plays the ♦7 and West discards a ♠.

You held up the ♦A until the third round to confirm that West has only 2. He does.

You cash four rounds of ♣s, ending in your hand.

East covers with the ♥Q.

Now play the ♥J. If East doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But East does cover so you must take dummy's ♥A.

West plays low.

A small ♥ from dummy, finessing the ♥9, hoping West has the ♥10. This is the Backward Finesse.

The Backward Finesse if a pretty rare play. It is against the odds so you only try it when you are absolutely certain that a normal finesse is doomed to fail.

Like this time.

By the way. Those of you with great short-term memories might think they have seen this hand before. Well, you ALMOST have. Deal 8 has an almost identical layout but a much simpler theme. Check it out.

Board 4
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ 10 4 2 ♥ A 8 3 ♦ A 10 7 2 ♣ K 6 4	
♠ K J 9 5 3 ♥ 10 6 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ 10 8 5	N W E S	♠ Q 8 ♥ Q J 9 4 2 ♦ 9 5 ♣ J 9 7 2
	♠ A 7 6 ♥ K 7 5 ♦ K J 6 3 ♣ A Q 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠5

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠5, dummy plays the ♠2 and East the ♠Q.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 8

Before worrying about where that one winner is going to come from you need to decide what to do with the opening lead. A good guideline is to hold up unless you fear a switch. Here, with all other suits well protected you would welcome a switch, so you let East win the ♠Q. East then plays the ♠8. Do you hold up again?

It probably doesn't matter, but since you cannot possibly win more than 10 tricks you might just as well hold up again. West wins the ♠J then plays the ♠3. East discards a ♥ on the third ♠.

OK, now it is time to figure out where that extra trick is coming from. Not much figuring is needed, it must come from the ♦ suit. Since you are missing 5 cards including the Queen, the odds favor a finesse over playing for the drop. And, since you have the option of finessing either defender are you going to finesse into the one who can set you or into the safe one?

You play the ♦K from your hand, then a small ♦, and West plays low.

Silly question. Of course you finesse into the safe hand: dummy's ♦10 wins the trick - and the game - and the overtrick.

Actually the odds slightly favored East holding the ♦Q because East started with only 2 ♠s compared to West's 5 ♠s. Therefore East had 11 spaces which could hold the ♦Q whereas West only had 8 spaces.

But in a situation like this you don't play odds. By finessing West you guaranteed making the contract even if the finesse lost because East had no more ♠s. Even a losing ♦ finesse would have established the one trick you needed.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 7 5 3 ♥ A 8 ♦ J 10 6 ♣ 10 9 4 3	
♠ 10 8 4 2 ♥ K 9 7 4 2 ♦ 8 5 3 ♣ 6	N W E S	♠ 6 ♥ Q J 10 3 ♦ 9 7 4 2 ♣ K 8 7 2
	♠ A Q J 9 ♥ 6 5 ♦ A K Q ♣ A Q J 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♦[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

East plays low again.

North is to play 6♠ after South's Stayman bid. East leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥5 and West the ♥2.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 2

This looks like a very simple plan. Since the hands have mirrored distribution there will be no discards anywhere. That means the ♣K **MUST** be in East's hand or you will go down. But is that all there is to it?

You have won the ♥A.

East plays low.

If East has ♣ K x or ♣ K x x then yes, that's all there is to it. But if he has ♣ K x x x then you won't have enough entries to your hand unless you take the first ♣ finesse **BEFORE** you start on trumps.

That is why you win the ♥A and immediately play a ♣ to dummy's ♣J, which holds the trick. Then pull trumps, (it takes 4 rounds), ending in your hand.

Your ♣10, putting on the ♣5 from dummy when East plays low again. This lets you stay in your hand to play another ♣ to the ♣Q, picking up all four ♣ tricks and the slam.

This Deal took a lot of care and attention. As you can see you had to take one ♣ finesse before you drew trumps because you were in your hand right then and you could only get back one more time.

But also you had to play to one of dummy's honors first so you could retain that ♣5 for letting you stay in your hand to make the third finesse. Bridge is great.